

Flow, Learning, and Empowerment: A Mixed-Methods Study of Female Adventure Tourists' Transformative Experiences

ABSTRACT

Adventure tourism is often discussed as a site of challenge, excitement, and empowerment, yet less is known about how women's momentary embodied experiences become translated into learning and psychological change. Focusing on Chinese female adventure tourists, this study examines how flow experience in soft adventure tourism contributes to learning, transformative learning, and psychological well-being. An exploratory sequential mixed-methods design was employed. Study 1 drew on 31 semi-structured interviews to explore women's experiences of hiking, cycling, camping, skiing, surfing, sailing, kayaking, diving, rock climbing, and paragliding. The qualitative findings show that flow was formed through bodily immersion, challenge–skill negotiation, risk awareness, and perceived control. These conditions made participants more attentive to their bodily capacities, practical limitations, interpersonal relations, and changing self-understandings. Building on these findings, Study 2 developed a structured questionnaire and obtained 512 valid responses from Chinese women with soft adventure tourism experience. Structural equation modelling showed that flow experience positively predicted instrumental, introspective, and communicative learning. Introspective learning had the strongest effect on transformative learning, suggesting that adventure experiences became psychologically meaningful when participants reinterpreted their abilities, assumptions, and life priorities. Transformative learning further enhanced psychological well-being, while social support strengthened the relationship between flow experience and learning outcomes. This study advances adventure tourism research by explaining the pathway through which embodied flow experience develops into learning-based transformation among Chinese female tourists. It also highlights the importance of designing adventure tourism experiences that support skill development, reflective meaning-making, and socially supportive participation environments.

Keywords: female adventure tourists; flow experience; transformative learning; psychological well-being; soft adventure tourism